

Art of Prompting

Questions Matter taught you how to frame the problem. Prompting is how you turn that frame into instructions the model can actually use.

You've learned how LLMs work: how they process tokens, use context, and generate responses word by word. Now here's the practical payoff: **the quality of your prompt directly controls the quality of the response.**

Bad Prompt, Better Prompt

01 Academic

✗ Bad Prompt

Help me study history.

AI OUTPUT

Sure! Here are some general tips for studying history: make a timeline, use flashcards, review your notes, and practice with past exams. Good luck!

✓ Better Prompt

I have an AP US History exam Friday. Quiz me on the political, economic, and social causes of the Civil War. Give me five questions, then check my answers and explain what I missed.

AI OUTPUT

Here are 5 questions on the causes of the Civil War:
1. What was the Missouri Compromise and why did it fail?
2. How did the economy of the South depend on slavery compared to the industrial North?
3. What role did the Dred Scott decision play in escalating tensions?
4. How did John Brown's raid on Harpers Ferry affect Southern fears?
5. What was the significance of Lincoln's election in 1860?
Answer when ready and I'll check your work.

02 Career

✗ Bad Prompt

Help me write a cover letter.

AI OUTPUT

Dear Hiring Manager, I am writing to express my interest in the internship position at your company. I am a hardworking student who is eager to learn and contribute to your team. I have good communication skills and work well with others. Thank you for your consideration.

✓ Better Prompt

I'm 17 applying for a summer internship at a local marketing agency. I have no work experience but I've run my school's Instagram account for two years and grown it from 200 to 1,400 followers. Write me a cover letter that leads with that as my main qualification and keeps it under 200 words.

AI OUTPUT

Dear Hiring Manager,

In two years managing my school's Instagram account, I grew our following from 200 to 1,400, not by posting more, but by studying what content our audience actually responded to and adjusting our strategy every month.

I'm looking to bring that same data-driven approach to your team this summer. I don't have traditional work experience, but I've learned to create content on a deadline, read analytics, and adapt when something isn't working.

I'd love the chance to learn from your agency while contributing real skills from day one.

THE TAKEAWAY

**Same ask.
Different prompt.
Different answer.**

The model can only answer with what you give it. A specific prompt with your real situation gets a real answer. A vague one gets a template.

WHY GOOD PROMPTS WORK

1 🧠 LLMs are pattern completers

LLMs run on patterns: specific prompts activate specific patterns, vague ones activate vague patterns. A precise input narrows the model to the best path.

2 📖 Context is everything

The model can only work with what's in its context window. A good prompt puts the right information in front of the model.

3 🎯 You're the director

Think of prompting as directing. The model fills in whatever you leave blank, sometimes well, sometimes not. A clear prompt replaces its defaults with your specifics.

The 8 Qualities

01 💡 CLARITY

Say exactly what you mean.

Vague prompts get vague answers.

02 📖 CONTEXT

Give the model the background it needs.

It can only work with what's in the context window.

03 🎯 SPECIFICITY

The more specific the ask, the more useful the answer.

Narrow the scope to what you actually need.

04 🧑 ROLE / PERSONA

Tell the model who to be.

A persona shapes tone, vocabulary, depth, and perspective.

05 📋 FORMAT INSTRUCTIONS

Tell the model how to shape the output.

Table, list, step by step: you choose.

06 🚫 CONSTRAINTS

Tell the model what not to do.

What you leave out shapes the answer as much as what you put in.

07 📖 EXAMPLES

Show it, don't just describe it.

One example of what you want teaches your style better than a paragraph. This is called few-shot prompting.

08 ✅ ONE TASK AT A TIME

One prompt, one job.

Break complex work into focused steps so each part lands.

THE TAKEAWAY

**Eight qualities.
One habit.**

Strong prompting isn't memorizing a list. It's the habit of telling the model what it needs to know.

Time to build one. Fill in the fields below. Watch your prompt come together as you go. Then see how it stacks up against a strong example.

YOU DON'T NEED ALL OF THESE EVERY TIME

Eight qualities looks like a lot. You don't need them all. A quick factual question ("who wrote The Great Gatsby") is fine with just Clarity. A real piece of work might stack four or five. The qualities are tools. Match them to the job. And they aren't app-specific: the same eight work in ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini.

Two diagnostic patterns: if you keep getting wrong-shaped responses (too long, too formal, too generic), that's usually missing Constraints or Format. If you keep getting answers that don't fit your situation, that's usually missing Context or Specificity.